

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

Christmas

Week 17

Week of Dec 14–18

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 17 · Week Overview

Christmas
Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

tree

star

present

bell

Santa

Littles (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **"Tree!"** (arms out like branches), **"Ho ho ho!"** (pat your belly, big laugh), **"Present!"** (shake a box beside your ear).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames: **"Merry Christmas!"**

"This is a present for you."

"I can see a star on the tree."

"Thank you!"

The week at a glance

MON	The Christmas Tree	a real pine sprig in the Magic Box (a small branch off a real tree)
TUE	A Star on Top	the gold star for the top of the tree, in the Magic Box; about twenty small gold paper stars...
WED	A Present for You	a wrapped present and a little bell in the Magic Box; the pass-the-present parcel, wrapped in...
THU	Ho Ho Ho, Santa!	a Santa hat and a big red stocking in the Magic Box; a mirror the children can see themselves...
FRI	Give the Gift + Big Review	the bell, and every prop from the week packed into the box (or a red sack); the presents the c...

2 MIN

Magic Box hook

4 MIN

Teach the words

3 MIN

Song · today's verse

3 MIN

Game · move it

1 MIN

Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: **"One, two, three — eyes on me!"** · Kids: **"One, two — eyes on you!"**

The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

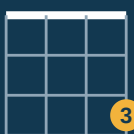
The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.

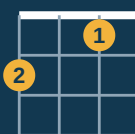
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G C E A

C

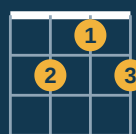
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G C E A

F

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G C E A

G7

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up ("ring — ring — ring-a"). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the bells.

The song needs only **C · F · G7**.

MONDAY

The Christmas Tree

Grab: a **real pine sprig** in the Magic Box (a small branch off a real tree — it has to smell); the bare classroom tree standing where everyone can reach it; the picture cards from print pack page 11; the tree card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box weighs almost nothing. Hold it up. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — silence. Now lift the lid a crack and **sniff**, loudly, with your eyes shut. Sniff again. Let your face go amazed.

TEACHER "Something in here smells like a whole **FOREST**." (*lift out the pine sprig and hold it under your own nose for one long beat*)

The sprig goes right round the circle and every child sniffs it. Arms out like branches: **"Tree!"**

4 MIN TEACH · TREE

Everybody stands up. We **are** the tree, twice — small and slow, then big:

My tree is **green**. (*arms out wide, fingers spread like branches*)

My tree is **TALL**. (*stretch right up on tiptoe*)

The lights go on... (*open and close both hands, twinkling*)

and a **star** on top of all! (*both hands to a point above your head*)

LITTLES do the branch arms and say **"Tree!"** **BIGS** take the frame: **"This is my Christmas tree."** **"The tree is green and tall."**

Then the bare tree itself. Walk round it once, touching nothing, and name what is **not** there yet: no lights, no star, nothing hanging. It is the emptiest tree in the world. Tomorrow the star, today everything else.

Teacher fails: try to hang a picture card on your own **head**, standing very still with your arms out. "Look. I am the tree." Hold the pose. Wait.

Chinese moment: lay the **tree** card at the foot of the tree and say **Christmas tree** once. Leave the card there all week; the row grows by one card a day.

3 MIN GAME · DECORATE THE TREE

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The picture cards are face down in a basket at the foot of the bare tree.

TEACHER "Take one card... **tell us what it is**... now hang it on the tree."

One child at a time: pick, name, hang. **LITTLES** name it with one word — **"Bell!"** **"Star!"** **BIGS** give the sentence as they hang it: **"I can see a star on the tree."**

Go all the way round; everybody hangs one thing. By the end the tree is covered and it was covered by them.

Leave it up all week. Everything that comes out of the Magic Box from today on has somewhere to live, and on Friday the presents go at its feet.

1 MIN CLOSE

Standing round the tree, branch arms out. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Tree... star... **PRESENT! MERRY CHRISTMAS!**" (*arms out · point up high · hands held out · both arms thrown wide on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Mr Willowby's Christmas Tree* (Robert Bary) — a tree gets cut shorter and shorter and every animal in the wood ends up with one. It is a giving book, which is this week's whole point.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · RING THE BELLS, IT'S CHRISTMAS!** chorus → Monday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** (*shake both hands like bells*)

F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** (*arms wide*)

C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, (*reach up, then right down to the floor*)

F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! (*pat your belly and laugh*)

MONDAY · TREE

C A little green tree, a little green tree, (*branch arms, small then big*)

G7 Lights and stars — **C** come and see! (*twinkling hands, then beckon*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole thing on Friday. Chords and the full sheet are on the Song tab. Sing it standing at the tree, always.

TUESDAY

A Star on Top

Today's words: **star** (*tree comes back every day*)

Grab: the **gold star** for the top of the tree, in the Magic Box; about twenty small gold paper stars, hidden round the room **before** the children come in; a torch; the star card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today there is exactly **one** thing in the box and it does not rattle. Chant, then tip the box slowly from side to side — something slides.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Peek in for a long time. Lift it out with **both** hands, very slowly, and turn it so the light catches the gold and flashes round the circle.

TEACHER "It's gold... it's pointy... and it goes **right at the very top.**" (*hold it above your own head*)

Hands to a point above their heads: **"Star!"**

4 MIN TEACH · STAR

The star sits in your two open hands while you say it — twice, and the second time they say it with you:

One gold star, (*hold it up in two hands*)

Right on the **TOP.** (*reach as high as you can*)

It shines all night... (*open and close both hands, twinkling*)

and it does **not stop!** (*keep twinkling, faster and faster*)

Then the real thing: one child is lifted up (or stands on a safe chair, held) to put the star on the tree while the whole class counts down — **three, two, one** — and cheers.

LITTLES point up high and say **"Star!"** **BIGS** owe you the sentence: **"I can see a star on the tree."** **"The star is on the top."**

Teacher fails: put the star carefully on the **floor** beside the tree, step back, fold your arms and admire it. "Beautiful." Wait. Let them march you back.

Chinese moment: the **star** card joins tree at the foot of the tree — stars. Sing one line of "Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star" with the torch on the ceiling. One line only, then stop.

3 MIN GAME · STAR HUNT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Twenty gold paper stars are hidden round the room, some in plain sight at knee height for the littlest ones.

TEACHER "Walking feet... find the stars... GO!" (*everything found comes straight back to the mat*)

When the hunt is over, lay every star out in one long line on the carpet and **count them all together**, out loud, pointing at each one. **LITTLES** count with their fingers up; **BIGS** count the line themselves and tell you: **"I found three stars."**

Hide exactly as many as the class can count to together, and count them into your hand before you hide them — the counting at the end is the real work, and it only works if the number comes out right.

1 MIN CLOSE

Standing at the tree, everybody's star held up. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Tree... star... PRESENT! MERRY CHRISTMAS!" (*arms out · point up high · hands held out · both arms thrown wide on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? Lights off, torch on the ceiling, and sing *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star* lying on your backs. It costs nothing and they will ask for it every day this week.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · RING THE BELLS, IT'S CHRISTMAS! chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** (*shake both hands like bells*)

F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** (*arms wide*)

C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, (*reach up, then right down to the floor*)

F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! (*pat your belly and laugh*)

TUESDAY · STAR

C One gold star right on the top, (*reach up high and hold it*)

G7 Twinkle, twinkle — **C** it will not stop! (*twinkling hands, faster and faster*)

Sing this verse getting *quieter* and the twinkling getting faster, until the last word is a whisper and only the hands are moving. Then straight back into the big chorus. They love the drop.

WEDNESDAY

A Present for You

Today's words: **present** (*tree · star come back*)

Grab: a **wrapped present** and a little **bell** in the Magic Box; the pass-the-present parcel, wrapped in one layer per child, with a bag of star stickers to share in the middle; music you can start and stop; wrapping paper, tape and ribbon on the shelf tray; the present card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box gives one bright *ting* when it moves. Chant, then shake it once — **ting** — and stop dead.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Lift out the **bell** and ring it once, high above your head. Everybody goes quiet on the ring — that is the rule for the rest of the week.

TEACHER "The bell means something is coming..." (*reach back in and lift out the wrapped present in both hands*)

Shake it beside your ear. **"Present!"**

4 MIN TEACH · PRESENT

The present stays in your hands the whole way through. Say it twice; the second time they do the actions with you:

A present, a present, tied with a **bow**, (*hold it up and trace the ribbon with one finger*)

What's inside? I do **not** know! (*shake it beside your ear, then shrug enormously*)

It's **not** for me... (*hands off it, both behind your back*)

it's for **YOU**, you know! (*hold it out to one child with two hands*)

Here is the whole week in one sentence, said slowly: **a present is a thing you give away**. Then send it round: two hands, eyes up, **"This is a present for you."** — and the child who takes it says **"Thank you!"** before passing it on.

LITTLES shake it beside their ear and say **"Present!"** **BIGS** owe you both halves: **"This is a present for you."** and **"Thank you!"**

Teacher fails: start tearing the paper off greedily with your teeth. "Mine. All mine." Wait for the roar — **"It's for YOU!"** — then look very ashamed and hand it on.

Chinese moment: the **present** card joins tree · star — present. And the two words that go with it every time something changes hands: **thank you** and **you're welcome**.

3 MIN GAME · PASS THE PRESENT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody in a circle, knees touching. Say the rule out loud **before** you start: there is **one layer for every child**, so everybody unwraps exactly once, and what is inside is for all of us.

TEACHER "Music on — pass it. Music STOPS — one layer off!" (*the child who takes the layer off then hands the parcel straight on*)

Round it goes. The waiting is the lesson and it is a hard one, so narrate it kindly: **"It's not your turn yet... and you are waiting so well."**

The last layer comes off to a bag of star stickers — one each, handed out by the child who opened it.

Never let the middle be a prize for one child. The whole game teaches waiting, and a single winner at the end quietly teaches the opposite.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody's hands held out flat, as if offering something. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Tree... star... PRESENT! MERRY CHRISTMAS!" (*arms out · point up high · hands held out · both arms thrown wide on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Jolly Christmas Postman* (Janet & Allan Ahlberg) — every page has a real envelope to open. Let a different child open each one and hand it round.

› **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · RING THE BELLS, IT'S CHRISTMAS!** chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** (*shake both hands like bells*)

F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** (*arms wide*)

C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, (*reach up, then right down to the floor*)

F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! (*pat your belly and laugh*)

WEDNESDAY · PRESENT

C A present, a present, tied with a **bow**, (*trace the bow in the air*)

G7 It's not for me — **C** it's for **YOU**, you know! (*hands to your chest, then out to a friend*)

On "it's for YOU" everybody points at somebody else, not at the teacher. Twenty children pointing at each other and laughing is exactly the feeling you want in the room on Friday.

THURSDAY

Ho Ho Ho, Santa!

Today's words: **Santa** (tree · star · present come back)

Grab: a **Santa hat** and a big red **stocking** in the Magic Box; a mirror the children can see themselves in; the Christmas card; paper and a pot to draw the **giving pairs** for tomorrow.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is **fat** and completely silent — press the lid down and it springs back up, soft.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it: nothing at all. Squash it: it bounces. Peek in and laugh out loud, then pull out something **red**, very slowly, and put it on your own head.

TEACHER "HO... HO... **HO!**" (both hands on your belly, laughing from right down low)

Everybody pats their belly. "**Ho ho ho!**" Then the enormous red stocking comes out and gets held up against a child, who disappears inside it.

4 MIN TEACH · SANTA

Hat on. Say it twice, the second time with everybody joining in:

Red, red hat, (pat the hat on your head)

A big white **beard**, (stroke a long beard down to your tummy)

He comes at **night**... (tiptoe on the spot, finger on your lips)

HO HO HO — he's **here!** (both hands on your belly, big laugh)

Then the mirror. Every child who wants to wears the hat for five seconds, looks at themselves and does one "**Ho ho ho!**" **LITTLES** need nothing else. **BIGS** give the sentence: "**Santa has a red hat.**" "**Santa gives presents to everybody.**"

Say the true thing once, plainly: Santa is a **story**. Some families tell it, some families don't, and both are completely normal — exactly like families being different. Then get straight back to the laughing.

Teacher fails: put the Santa hat carefully on your **foot** and stand there beaming. "How do I look?" Hold it. Wait.

Chinese moment: the **Christmas** card joins the row — Father Christmas — and the whole class says **Merry Christmas!** once, at full volume.

Nobody has to wear it. If a child is frightened of the hat or the beard, it sits on your knee, on the far side of the circle, and nothing is said about it at all.

3 MIN GAME · SANTA SAYS

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Simon says, played in a red hat — and every instruction is one of the week's words.

TEACHER "**Santa says**... ring the bells! **Santa says**... hang a star! ... **wrap a present!**" (the last one has no "Santa says" — freeze and look round)

Actions: ring the bells (shake both hands) · hang a star (reach up high) · wrap a present (wrap in the air) · be a tree (branch arms) · HO HO HO (pat your belly). Nobody is ever out; a child who moves just does it again with you.

Last round, the hat goes to a Big and **they** give the orders while you play in the circle like everybody else.

Five instructions, no more — the same five, over and over, faster and faster. That repetition is the English lesson; new instructions would only make it a listening puzzle.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody's hands on their bellies, ready. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Tree... star... **PRESENT! MERRY CHRISTMAS!**" (arms out · point up high · hands held out · both arms thrown wide on the shout)

Before home time: draw the **giving pairs** for tomorrow — every child's name pulled out of the stocking, so that everybody gives one present and everybody receives one. Check the list twice tonight; a child holding a present with nowhere to take it is the one thing that can spoil Friday.

Got 3 spare minutes? *Dear Santa* (Rod Campbell) — lift-the-flap, one flap per child, and they will shout "too big!" at you every time.

J TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · RING THE BELLS, IT'S CHRISTMAS! chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** (shake both hands like bells)

F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** (arms wide)

C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, (reach up, then right down to the floor)

F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! (pat your belly and laugh)

THURSDAY · SANTA

C Red, red hat and a big white beard, (pat your head, stroke the beard)

G7 Ho, ho, ho! — **C** Santa's here! (three belly laughs, then arms wide)

Do the three "ho"s lower each time, like a big slow drum. By tomorrow they will be doing the voice without you.

FRIDAY

Give the Gift + Big Review

Today's words: **bell** — and **tree · star · present**
· **Santa**, the whole week

Grab: the **bell**, and every prop from the week packed into the box (or a red sack); the **presents the children made**, hidden until the game; the giving-pairs list from yesterday; the awards (print pack page 17); the give card.

Monday is the start of the **winter holiday** — back on **4 January**.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out bulging and will not quite shut.

TEACHER "Today the box is **FULL** — it's got our whole **WEEK** inside it!"

Pull each thing out and hold it up in complete silence. They will supply the word before you can.

The pine sprig → "**Tree!**" The gold star → "**Star!**" The wrapped present → "**Present!**" The red hat → "**Santa!**"

Last of all, one small thing left in the bottom. Lift it out and ring it, high. "**BELL!**"

4 MIN TEACH · BELL, THEN THE WHOLE WEEK

Everybody stands. We tell the whole week with our bodies, twice — slow, then fast:

Ring the bell — it's Christmas Day! (*shake both hands like bells*)

A **tree**, (*branch arms*) a **star**, (*point right up high*)

A **present** to give away, (*hold both hands out to a friend*)

And a **HO HO HO!** (*pat your belly*)

Merry Christmas — **I love you!** (*hands over your heart, then blow a kiss*)

LITTLES do the five gestures and shout the five words. **BIGS** owe you a whole sentence each: "**I can see a star on the tree.**" "**This is a present for you.**" "**Merry Christmas!**"

Teacher fails: on "a present to give away", clutch the present to your chest with both arms and shake your head. Hold on tight. Let them prise it out of you.

Chinese moment: the **give** card joins the row — tree · star · present · Christmas · give, the whole week on the mat, and give is the one that matters: *to give*. Then tell them: **Winter Solstice** falls on the 22nd, while we are all at home, and in the north we eat dumplings at the Winter Solstice — families sit down together and eat dumplings. Fold an imaginary dumpling with them, all twenty pairs of hands.

3 MIN GAME · GIVE THE GIFT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Every child fetches the present they made and sits down holding it. Nobody opens anything until the very end — say so first, and say it twice.

TEACHER (*ring the bell once*) "Whose turn? ... Off you go."

One bell, one child: they walk across the circle, hand it over with **two hands** and look at the person: "**This is for you.**" The one who receives it says "**Thank you!**" Then the bell rings again for the next child. **LITTLES** say the one word with the two hands — "**Present!**" — and that is a full win.

When every present has been given, and only then: **open them all together**, on the count of three.

Use yesterday's pairs, and hold the list in your hand. Every child gives one and receives one — count it twice before you start. This is the moment of the whole term; it is worth the extra two minutes of preparation.

1 MIN CLOSE + AWARDS

Every child gets a "You are a STAR!" award to take home with the holiday news. Then, standing round the tree with their presents, all five gestures:

EVERYONE "Tree... star... PRESENT! MERRY CHRISTMAS!" (*arms out · point up high · hands held out · both arms thrown wide, and everybody rings the bells on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? Sing the whole song one more time with the lights off and the tree lit. Then wish them a happy holiday, in both languages, and tell them the date they come back: **Monday 4 January**.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · RING THE BELLS, IT'S CHRISTMAS!** Friday's verse, then the **WHOLE** song, top to bottom

CHORUS

C Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** (*shake both hands like bells*)

F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** (*arms wide*)

C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, (*reach up, then right down to the floor*)

F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! (*pat your belly and laugh*)

FRIDAY · MERRY CHRISTMAS

C Bells and stars and presents too, (*ring · point up · hands out*)

G7 Merry Christmas — **C** I love you! (*hands to heart, then blow a kiss*)

The finale: chorus → Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday → chorus, standing all the way round the tree with the presents piled at its feet and nobody touching them. They learned it one verse a morning without ever noticing, and this run-through is the review of the whole week.

★ Ring the Bells, It's Christmas!

Week 17 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** Ring, ring, ring the **F** bells! **C** *(shake both hands like bells)*
F Christmas **C** Day is **G7** here! **C** *(arms wide)*
C A star on **F** top, a present down be **C** low, *(reach up, then right down to the floor)*
F Merry **C** Christmas, everyone — **G7** HO HO **C** HO! *(pat your belly and laugh)*

MONDAY · TREE

- C** A little green tree, a little green tree, *(branch arms, small then big)*
G7 Lights and stars — **C** come and see! *(twinkling hands, then beckon)*

TUESDAY · STAR

- C** One gold star right on the top, *(reach up high and hold it)*
G7 Twinkle, twinkle — **C** it will not stop! *(twinkling hands, faster and faster)*

WEDNESDAY · PRESENT

- C** A present, a present, tied with a bow, *(trace the bow in the air)*
G7 It's not for me — **C** it's for YOU, you know! *(hands to your chest, then out to a friend)*

THURSDAY · SANTA

- C** Red, red hat and a big white beard, *(pat your head, stroke the beard)*
G7 Ho, ho, ho! — **C** Santa's here! *(three belly laughs, then arms wide)*

FRIDAY · MERRY CHRISTMAS

- C** Bells and stars and presents too, *(ring · point up · hands out)*
G7 Merry Christmas — **C** I love you! *(hands to heart, then blow a kiss)*

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“ring — ring — ring-a”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the bells.

Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **G7** → **C**. That is the entire chorus, and the whole song is those three shapes — there is no Am this week at all, so if last week's verses defeated you, this is the one to come back on. C is one finger, F is two, G7 is three; learn them in that order. If your fingers get stuck, put the uke down, give one child the real bell and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.